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Louis Hayes

Drummer and band leader Louis Hayes was born in Detroit on May 31, 1937. He was performing professionally while still in his teens and moved to New York in 1956. Between 1956 and 1967, Louis was an integral part of the Horace Silver Quintet, the Cannonball Adderley Quintet and the Oscar Peterson Trio. He has led a number of influential ensembles since the early 1970's, employing numerous well known soloists, including Freddie Hubbard, Joe Henderson and Rene McLean. The Woody Shaw-Louis Hayes Quintet acted as the host group for Dexter Gordon's 1976 return to the United States. Louis has recorded prolifically and continues to propel the rhythm sections of jazz ensembles here and abroad.

Louis was interviewed in New York City on January 29, 2000, by Monk Rowe, director of the Hamilton College Jazz Archive.

MR: We are filming in Manhattan today. My name is Monk Rowe with the Hamilton College Jazz Archive. I'm very pleased to have Louis Hayes with me, one of jazz's great drummers.

LH: Monk, it's a pleasure to be here.

MR: Band leader and composer on occasion, and it's really a pleasure to speak with you. I was fortunate to see you at the Iridium last night, and some of those tempos were just — talk about hard bop, I mean, very, very hard.

LH: Yeah, that was a lot of fun, and especially starting off the night like that. When I was much younger, Freddie Hubbard and myself, we used to do that. What was the tune we used to play? "Just One of Those Things." We used to start off like that. That was nightly, just to get yourself loosened up and get yourself together. A staggering pace, I mean, fast as you could go. And really challenging.

MR: I feel sorry for the bass player sometimes actually, when it goes on and on. But you expend an awful lot of energy too.

LH: Yes.

MR: But have you ever had a problem with keeping up that for very long?

LH: Well actually no I don't. Because I practice, and I warm up every day before I come to a job. And I like practicing. Now when I was a youngster naturally I had problems keeping up. But once I grew up a little bit and came through, started getting a little older and getting a little more experience and I got to the point where I could handle it, I've never had a problem since. Because I've always stayed in shape. And when you practice for a long period of time then it's not that big of a deal. But naturally, and I don't spend too

much energy as far as moving around physically — my head and body and everything — I'm more or less a person that just deals with less motion as possible.

MR: I notice on occasion it looks like you're singing, or speaking to yourself as you play.

LH: Yes. Now see I noticed that on video cameras. I never knew it was coming out like that...

MR: Oh really.

LH: ...until somebody videoed me, and that is something that just happens.

MR: You're not saying anything specific then?

LH: No, no. Although sometimes I might be thinking about I'll be glad when this guy stops soloing. But I think it's just a facial...

MR: Yeah. Well sometimes it also looked like you were mouthing the melody with the guys too, which may have happened. But I always like to watch that kind of group. I mean this wasn't a group that works together a lot.

LH: No.

MR: But on occasion you guys would lay into something, and I was wondering like, well, is that rehearsed or is that a lick that's kind of standard with the song. Like I wrote one down and it went [scats]. And you were playing that with the horns and behind somebody's solo. I can't recall the tune though.

LH: I don't know what it could have been because we didn't rehearse. But it is — music, this art form, when you know the guys, it does have a language. And everyone who can play, and know each other and play on a certain level, you know the language to this art form. So you can do things that the audience might think it's been rehearsed but actually we didn't rehearse. It's the first time, actually, since we're doing this job, that we've played together. And McPherson, he lives in San Diego, and had a lot of problems with the weather when he was coming in so he didn't arrive, we opened Tuesday, but he arrived Wednesday. So we didn't do any rehearsing.

MR: Well you grew up in a pretty musical atmosphere.

LH: I did.

MR: Detroit was a good city for music in general?

LH: Yes it really was. My father played piano and drums, and my mother played piano. And I started out playing piano, actually started out with playing piano. Most kids started out playing — because the piano is in the homes mostly. So I did that for a while. But the piano to me was, at five or six, it wasn't fun. I think doing anything, if it's too complicated or not fun, and someone has to more or less as a job make you do it, that causes a problem. And piano causes me a problem. But drums were there in the house also, and I started just playing drums and drums were fun to me. It was actually fun. And I realized that kids that were older than I was playing drums, how much difficulty they

were having doing certain things, and I looked at them and it was easy for me. So that made me, I felt good about that, because I could accomplish things real fast that they were having a lot of problems with. And then I had a — had, now he's passed away — a cousin, that he played drums very well. He didn't come to New York. If he'd a came to New York in the 40's he would have been very well known. His name was Clarence Stamps. But he didn't. And he started teaching me. And I learned a lot from him. That's how I really started getting together was him teaching me these things.

MR: Yeah. Was there a point, let's say in high school, that you decided that you were going to be a musician, for a living?

LH: Yes, yes. I say I was about fifteen. I had been playing before then, but by the time of fifteen I knew that that was what I wanted to do was play.

MR: And was this the time you played with Yusef Lateef?

LH: Yes. Well I'd been playing much before then. Actually I had my own group. One day my mother sent me to help this lady wash her windows. So I went over and this lady and her husband were managing a teenage club. So we had got in this conversation, I told him I had a group, so he hired me to bring a group. And that's when I started. But I was playing before then, little dances and they used to have, what do you call it, street dances where they' block off the street and people would have them — things like that, and at school I'd play. But when I first started putting a band together was then. I played at this teenage club in Detroit. And I was about maybe fifteen or sixteen then. And then from there, and Detroit, it was a very competitive place. And the older musicians, they were sort of on such a high level, the musicians that I was looking at, like Tommy Flanagan and actually Yusef and so many of them, Kenny Burrell. But they didn't realize that I played drums though, because I never would play around them, I had my own compadres that I was beating up on. So anyway I played at a couple of teenage clubs. Then with Yusef I was working in this club, a night club, and I wasn't supposed to be in the club because a person, you're supposed to be 21 to work in nightclubs, and I was about 17 or 18. But this club owner, he liked me a lot. So when Yusef got the job he said to Yusef you can have the job but Louis Hayes, you have to take Louis with the job. Yusef didn't know me at the time. So he came over to my mother's house, where I was staying at the time, and he said you've got the job but I'm going to give you a six weeks trial, which was fantastic — six weeks. That was great. So that was Yusef and Curtis Fuller was playing trombone and Hugh Lawson piano, and Ernie Farrell was the bassist. And I went in with them and I had a wonderful learning period until they found out how old I was eventually. And then that was the end of that job. But right after that I had another job in another club. But after that I was in this place called The West End which was a place in Detroit that guys,

it was an after hours place. And Kenny Burrell, actually his wife at the time, her name was Laura, I think it was his first wife, and her family owned this restaurant. And it was an after hours place, a place that had good food, and a place that musicians came after their job at night, after two o'clock, and played all night until five or six in the morning. And there was anotherr place also that musicians who came from New York and thought they were on such a high level, they would invite them out to this club and unless you were very special, you'd be embarrassed out there. So I was playing out there this one night and Kenny Burrell and Doug Watkins, who had left and they were living here in New York but they were back home for whatever reason, and we had an opportunity to sit in and play with them that night. So when they came back to New York the Jazz Messengers were disbanding, and Horace Silver was starting his group and Art Blakey was keeping the name the Jazz Messengers and they were separating. So Doug was appearing with Horace at the time, so Arthur Taylor was the original drummer when he first started. But Horace, so I understand, and Arthur, they didn't get along at all too great together. So Doug Watkins says well I know a person, let's get the baby boy out of Detroit. So Horace called me, and I thought one of my buddies were playing a little joke on me. So I didn't think it was really Horace Silver calling me up. I was 19 years old I think, he was calling me up. But it was Horace. So that's how — that was in '56, in August of '56 — so that's how I first came to New York.

MR: And you have played, well you played on "Sister Sadie" with him?

LH: Yes.

MR: And all the great tunes over the years. Was his style — semi-funky at the time — something that you had experienced before or have any trouble assimilating to?

LH: Now Horace, I learned so much from him, but we were in tune and it wasn't any problem from the beginning. It was very comfortable, very relaxed. We would rehearse at his apartment and he had these different albums that he asked me to listen to, and that was very — an experience — because these albums that he asked me to listen to, Art Blakey was on, and so that was a big challenge to be listening to Art Blakey and that was what I was supposed to replace. But no, Horace was very easy going and I really didn't have — I wasn't uncomfortable at all. It took me actually a little time to really start growing, to become where I was able to get strong enough really to feel comfortable handling things. With Horace, the album at the time he called them, I could really see my growth in the albums that I made with Horace. I could really tell from the first one until, I did five with him before I left in '59. And I could really see my growth and listen and hear my growth when I was appearing with Horace.

MR: You went on to play with who I consider one of the great saxophonists of all time, Cannonball, and record Nat's great tunes —

LH: Numerous.

MR: How did that gig come about?

LH: Well in the original Birdland on 52nd Street, I don't remember which night it was, but every week it was like a session night. Monday night, or one of those nights like that . So this night I was appearing there with Hank Mobley, tenor saxophone, and Booker Little, trumpet, Bobby Timmons, bass and Sam Jones — Bobby Timmons piano and Sam Jones bass. And Sam was in Cannon's first group, so we had a very nice time, with Sam, it was the first time we played together, but we were very compatible. So Sam asked me would I consider joining Cannonball's band. So I started thinking about it. So we went back and forth, because with Horace, we were so close in the band at the time, we were very comfortable with each other, because everybody knew after a period of time that's what happens. But I was considering making a change, I was young and I was thinking about doing something else. So that sounded very interesting to me. So eventually I did. And I'm very glad that I made the change, that was another experience, and Cannonball and Nat and Sam and myself, we became such good friends, and we were so close musically, and we were on stage and off, I mean the best of friends. I mean we hung out all the time. And with Cannon we got to be so close, with that group it was like a family. We were together all the time, even when we came home, came back to New York, we had parties. The band was the first ones that was invited, the band and their families. That's who we played with, who we partied with, between the record company, it was Orrin Keepnews at the time, and John Levy was taking care of the management business, so we were just that close, that kind of a group. I know Miles used to ask me every once in a while to join, to come and join his group at that time. And I really wanted to — you know, Miles Davis. But I couldn't do that because Cannonball and Nat, we just were too close.

MR: Did the band rehearse at all?

LH: Yes, we rehearsed, but it wasn't like Horace though. Now Horace rehearsed quite a bit. And when he went into the studio Horace — we had played the choruses, played the compositions, so all the little things were worked out, what we were going to do. But with Cannon it wasn't like that. Cannon was more spontaneous. We rehearsed, we had it together, but everybody was so talented we didn't — it was more spontaneous. We didn't rehearse all the time like that.

MR: Did you have a feeling when you did some of the tunes like "The Work Song" and "Jive Samba," that these were going to be hits? I'm not sure how you define a hit in the jazz world.

LH: I understand, yes.

MR: But did you go away with a feeling like man we've got something there?

LH: No, I didn't. And sometimes, I know myself, sometimes — I enjoyed the playing, good music, I always enjoy, especially when you're playing with creative people like Cannon and Nat and Yusef and Charles Lloyd and Sam Jones. But sometimes I didn't, I thought the stuff was kind of square, especially "The Work Song."

MR: You thought it was square, yeah.

LH: Yeah.

MR: You want me to go buh buh?

LH: And this was something, you know, we had to play this every night, doggone it.

MR: That's great to hear. You just never know.

LH: Yeah. Because I was much younger, and I wanted to be, you know I've tried my best to be as creative as possible, and some of those things I had to learn about business. Music is a business. And so I had to kind of start getting it together and learning about that because I was looking at it just for fun and being creative, and I wasn't looking at things that way a lot of times at that time.

MR: Yeah. I mean so that's a learning experience in itself.

LH: Yes.

MR: If you want to be successful sometimes, you can't play exactly the way you had envisioned at certain times.

LH: Yes. At certain times.

MR: Yeah. Can you tell me anything about this album? Was there anything about Cannonball and Nancy that stuck out in your memory at all?

LH: Well this was another thing that just — well I would say that Nancy being from Ohio, I think it's Columbus, there was a club there had some numbers, like 502 or something like that. And I had appeared there with Horace Silver actually in '58 or like that time, and I met Nancy there. And Cannon had appeared there also with Miles Davis, and he knew Nancy Wilson and they got to be close during that time. So when Nancy came to New York she got in touch with Cannonball and she became very close with Cannonball and Nat and Nat's wife Ann. They became very close. So this record date was something where we didn't rehearse a lot doing this date. We put together things — we put this together in the studio most of the time, we didn't have a big rehearsal, and it just came together. But it was so comfortable that — there was another person in Chicago, disc jockey, his name was Sid McCoy. And Daddy-O. There was two of them. But Sid McCoy especially, we all were very close. And Sid McCoy really played this album a lot. And Cannonball and Nancy, we had such a rapport, and people, this was the album that

just took off, and everybody loved it. So we did a lot of concerts together at places, Cannonball and Nancy. And it started out, it was amazing. It started out like that, Cannonball and Nancy. We did a lot of things together, we had a great time, a lot of history. But then I noticed the sign changed to Nancy Wilson/Cannonball. That's what was very interesting. But that relationship with Nancy, that was a wonderful, great relationship.

MR: Yeah, it was tight arrangements, even though you say that they were a bit spontaneous, but I mean you could tell that you and Sam were like this.

LH: Right.

MR: What was it — Joe Zawinul replaced Bobby Timmons?

LH: No, I think he replaced Victor Feldman.

MR: And Wynton Kelly was in there somewhere too.

LH: Wynton Kelly, but he wasn't actually with the group but we recorded together. I can't recall the name of the album at the time, but we did record together. I think Bobby Timmons was the original pianist, and then Barry Harris was there, that's right, Barry Harris was there for a period of time, and then Victor Feldman. And then really the major pianist was Joe Zawinul. He was there for years, at least ten years.

MR: Yeah. What was he like to work with?

LH: Joe was wonderful. Joe, actually, Joe when he first joined the band Joe was kind of nervous, because he hadn't been in that situation before. He had been appearing with Dinah Washington, which was — Joe's facilities were marvelous, but that was a little different accompanying a vocalist naturally. But this was, with Cannonball, it was every person for himself. You had to be ready, creative, you know. Everybody was on their own. So Sam and myself, we used to have these meetings. Because we were so close, you know, friends. So we would have these meetings and sit in the room at night, after the job, and discuss these things. And Joe, he was a little nervous at first, but he worked out just wonderful, worked out just fine.

MR: Good writer.

LH: Oh great, great. And a marvelous, interesting person. You know he's from Vienna. And him as a person, Joe is a very — we got along so well together. We were very close, good friends.

MR: Right. Well you went from there to kind of a different situation with Oscar Peterson.

LH: Yes.

MR: How did the piano trio differ from the Cannonball thing?

LH: Well that was for me, Oscar being on the highest level a person can be on in this art form, you know Oscar is, and he was like that, he was very consistent. He was like that every

night. And he's such — everything is so great with Oscar. Him as a person, the way he carried the trio, being around, being in his company, everything was a great experience. But I wasn't as comfortable with Oscar as I was with Horace or Cannon because with Horace and Cannon it was horns and I had my freedom to be creative and then play and do exactly what I wanted to do at all times. It was never — I had no restrictions on me at all with Horace or Cannon. Anything that I felt like doing, go for it. I mean just do what you feel like, please. But with Oscar it was more or less like — how should I put this — star, co-star situation, where he was leading and he wanted the rhythm section to accompany him a certain way. So that was more of a problem for me, because for the first time I had these restrictions. And that, I mean playing with him was a great experience. But that did, I felt, limit my creativity to a point. So it was harder for me to deal with Oscar because it was so demanding but then again I had to really think about what I was doing more.

MR: Yeah, and that maybe I have to limit some things that I would like to do.

LH: Exactly. Right. Yes.

MR: Did this have any play on the fact that shortly after that you became a co-leader and leading your own groups?

LH: Yes. Because with Oscar I — I did it twice, went back. The first time, after Cannon was — '65 — and I went with him again, until something like '71, '72 or around that time. But before, now Freddie Hubbard and myself, we were very good friends. We were the same age. So we lived in the same building in Brooklyn. So we were creating. He was upstairs and I was downstairs. So we were with each other and creating and making music all the time. So that was something that I really was enjoying doing at the time. Naturally playing with Oscar, that was my job. But with Freddie, we were having so much fun. I wasn't making that much money with Freddie, but we were making history. We were having a lot of fun, me and Freddie Hubbard. So I was doing that all the time, and we had this group we had he called The Communicators. It was Freddie Hubbard and Joe Henderson and Kenny Barron, pianist, and Herbie Lewis was the bassist originally. So Freddie and myself, we, over the years, we played together for all these years and we're still doing it. So that's what I was doing. But after that, it was Cedar Walton who lived around the corner in Brooklyn from us. And he had been in Europe with his quartet. And when he came back he said to me one day that this person from Holland, whose name was Wim Wit, asked him about me bringing a group over. So at the time I didn't have a group. So I put one together. I got Junior Cook and Ron Matthews and Stafford James, and then we got Woody Shaw. So it was the Louis Hayes-Junior Cook Quintet featuring Woody Shaw. And that's the way that came about. And I got this, also I knew

this lady, her name was Maxine Craig at the time, who originally was Maxine Gordon, Dexter Gordon's wife, but she was managing it. We went to Europe, and that's how I started having my own bands. That was the first one.

MR: Was it a different experience to be making decisions, and what kind of decisions did you have to make as leader?

LH: Well musically I was making decisions, and I felt very comfortable doing that. In that role I always felt comfortable with the guys and they felt comfortable with me, and I had this lady for management, see? So one of the problems I feel is — naturally working all the time is a major problem — but in that situation everybody really getting along — it seems like it's very hard sometimes to get a group where everybody's really compatible over a long period of time. Because people — we were young and people have these different ideas about things and directions they want to go in, and so that can cause different things — everybody makes changes. So that's what happened. We were together for a period of time and then it was time to make a change. So Woody got his own group and I made a change and got a quartet at the time with Frank Strozier and Harold Mabern and Stafford James stayed there for a period of time. And now that quartet — both things were very creative. I enjoyed the group with Junior and Woody and Woody was actually so talented, Woody Shaw, boy he's such a great player. And he recorded this tune that I had written for my wife entitled "Nesha." And he played it so beautifully, I mean that's one of my favorite things by Woody. And with Frank Strozier, he was so talented with that group. I mean he's ... but that group, I felt like that group should have really taken off. But business for some reason wasn't taken care of right with that one so eventually we disbanded and it came apart.

MR: I'm curious. This was mid-60's?

LH: No this was into the 70's.

MR: Okay. It was kind of a tough decade for jazz, wasn't it?

LH: Exactly right.

MR: Yeah. And there was a lot of different things happening, of course you're coming out of Coltrane and you had some free jazz and you had soul jazz. Did this band have a definition of what you played so when your manager went to try to find work for you — I guess what I'm trying to say is did you label yourself?

LH: No we didn't label ourselves. But we were — the group with the quartet with Frankie and Harold we were so actually dynamic, and so much power, and we knew that we had this ability to perform on such a level that we felt like this is it, this would work. Because when we would appear opposite anyone, they were in serious trouble, I mean the group was very dynamic. It was — Harold Mabern was something to look at, and he was so

percussive. And Frank, I mean Frank is so knowledgeable on the saxophone. And so when that group broke up, Frank was so disappointed he stopped playing. And he stopped playing piano. And naturally he was a school teacher, so he was teaching school, and he was trying to get out of that teaching school thing. And he went back to teaching. He was so disappointed, and he gave music up and he stopped playing the piano. And actually that was in the — I think the late 70's or 80's or early 80's or 70's. And he hasn't, I don't think he's ever got the saxophone out or played again since then. He was very disappointed.

MR: Yeah. It's too bad.

LH: Yes.

MR: Well you recorded some marvelous records, you and Woody and I wanted to read a quote that someone wrote about you in one of the jazz encyclopedia type of things, and see if you think this sums you up. It says "Louis Hayes plays in a compelling forceful style marked by a tendency to push the beat and to goad the soloists with frequent fills."

LH: Yeah, that's, yes.

MR: All right, good.

LH: Yes. I feel great about that, yes. Because I came up in a way where I felt I liked being accompanist but I like doing it on my terms. Because this art form, I always wanted to play it, one of the reasons is because you can accompany a person but you can be your own person, you have your own voice in doing that. So that's what I really — one of the things I've always, I mean the wonderful things about this art form, you can get your own voice, you can have your own voice, and that is one of the main things that you are there for, to do things your own way. So being able to accompany people, I mean soloing was something that I have facilities, and you have to do, being a drummer, is take solos and things. But originally I was thinking about accompanying. That's the way I started out playing.

MR: Your solo last night in one of the tunes had a great kind of crescendo to it, you know, it sounded like you were playing Bebop rhythms. But by the time you were — you had this impact of almost constant sound. It was like, I don't know how you were doing it, but it was nice.

LH: Thank you very much. Thank you, Monk.

MR: The Dexter Gordon thing, you had that classic album with him too. That must have been a nice experience.

LH: It really was.

MR: At the Vanguard.

LH: Yes, yes. That was a great experience. That was with Woody. We had that group and Woody, excuse me I mean Dexter, was staying in Copenhagen at the time, and also Slide Hampton was living in Europe. So this lady Maxine, she talked to him about coming back to New York at the time, and Dexter wanted to do that. But he didn't have a group. So when they put that together on, what was it Columbia? That album?

MR: I think it was, yeah.

LH: Columbia — Dexter made this into "Live at the Vanguard" and actually that was the Louis Hayes-Woody Shaw group but with Dexter. People were — it was such a big thing, for Dexter to come back. I mean the club was just packed every night, and it was such a warm feeling. It was a great experience. So we did some more things with Dexter at the time, but I'm glad I had that opportunity to make that history with Dexter at the time.

MR: Yeah. He certainly had a persona to him.

LH: Oh he had, that was —

MR: The way he spoke and just his movements and all.

LH: Exactly right. Dexter was one-of-a-kind, that's for sure.

MR: Do you have any opinions about the jazz scene today?

LH: Well I feel like it's a little more difficult I feel for young artists to come here and get that experience working with bands that have great leaders. During when I came along, I mean everybody feels you have to come along whenever you're born, but I feel like during that time it was still the last of it, but it was still a time when you had a few bands out here that had great leaders. And you could go from one band to another band and get that experience. Now speaking to like a person that was my mentor, Jo Jones, Papa Jo, who came with Count Basie here, speaking to him and him speaking to me actually, when he came here in the 30's with Count Basie, that was the greatest time of all. Now at least I mean with the big band, and I know he used to tell me when he wanted to hear some musicians playing, he said, when they had those dancing girls in front of the band, he said the guys were really performing at that time. But when I came, still the big band era had passed but they still had a lot of major leaders that you could play with and you learned during that time. But now you don't have a lot of groups that have this fantastic — and leaders on eye level like during that time. So the record companies, they take young guys and give them these contracts and make leaders out of people that I don't think are ready to be leaders. So actually, to me, people a lot of times are too young to have really a strong direction. So to me it starts lowering the creativity and the art form because they are making — and they're looking over a lot of people that are still able to really perform on a level, and they're just going for the youngsters, the younger

musicians, and I think that is really to a point hurting the art form because it's putting people in positions they shouldn't be in.

MR: Right. It's a marketing ploy almost, and it's not honoring the music as much as it should.

LH: Exactly. Yes. Yes. So I think that is causing a little problem there.

MR: And I guess the a number of clubs is not what it used to be. It must be a little harder to ... how do you find work?

LH: Well at this point I do several things. But mainly I have a group, a quintet, and we just recorded two CD's on the label TCB, on a label out of Switzerland. And one is coming out March 14th and another one I'm not sure exactly when it's going to be released, that one. And I have this management team, a person that books Basil's, James Brown and Martha Burretts, that's my management team. So I'm basically involved with my group and I'm having a wonderful time with that and it's growing. So that's my main concern with what I'm doing right now is that quintet.

MR: Who's in the group?

LH: Riley Mullins is the trumpeter, and Abraham Burton, he plays tenor saxophone, and Santi Debriano, he's the bassist, and Dave Hazeltine, he's the pianist.

MR: Are you the most experienced guy in the band?

LH: I'm the oldest, and the most experienced actually. I remember when I was the baby boy, that's what changes up as time goes up it changes.

MR: Wow. I have one little piece of music to play here.

[audio interlude]

LH: That's what I just mentioned to you.

MR: Now as a composer, do you sit at the piano and work out things?

LH: No actually, I wish I could actually. But my piano facilities are not that great. So I put this tune together in my head and I sang it in a tape recorder.

MR: I love that. That's great, yeah.

LH: And it gave me, I mean that was a job. I mean I had this record date so I wanted to think of something. And my wife and myself naturally we were close as could be. But sometimes we would have little problems, as men and women when you're married, so I'm trying to do something and think of something to help get me out of this, on the good side. So I had to think of this, I had to write this composition and dedicate it to my wife, very important. So I sat there on the couch and I started putting this together. And I put it together and after I got it in my head and I sang it in this machine, I went to the pianist at the time Ronnie Matthews, and I explained it to him, and he made music out of it, put the chord changes to it, and that's how it came about.

MR: That's great. I don't wish any more arguments on you but if you come up with tunes, maybe the good times could lead to a tune too.

LH: Yeah my wife after she heard it she said "you didn't write it, you didn't write that." So I had to go and get that original singing and whistling I was doing.

MR: That's great to have though.

LH: Yes.

MR: It came from this kind of raw inspiration and look what came out of it.

LH: Yes. So after that she bought me this little thing, this little machine that I can just click it on and when I have an idea right there, just sing right in to it.

MR: Great. Good story. You like playing overseas?

LH: Yes, yes. I think it's changed over the years. And well I say it like this. Overseas I was working, especially with my groups, more so than in America or anyplace else. I was doing Europe more than anyplace, because we would go over for long periods of time, six weeks, and I had quite a few groups that I've taken over there over the years. I had this person that was booking me over there quite a bit. But I got to the point where the venues that I was playing in, I got to the point where I didn't feel like doing that anymore, playing in clubs. I wanted to do more concerts and things, and I got kind of to the point where I'd done these other things so much that I just didn't want to do it anymore. So I just stopped going over. I haven't been going over lately. But I'm going back this summer coming up. My management team and the record company put some things together. But they are festivals. So I'm going over to do about four festivals this summer coming up. And I like that much more.

MR: Just to wrap up here, because I know you have to go to work, do you have any words of advice for a musician who just graduated from Berklee and wants to be enmeshed in the jazz world?

LH: Well I feel that if you know you're good at what you do, it's just something where it just takes being — you'll find your way. I always say to people if you are able to come to New York and be around for a while, you will find just how you fit in, because there are so many different scenes. So it's just a matter of time. And if you have the talent, I don't think it would be — and you know that's what you want to do. I think a lot of people are just not sure of what they want to do. But when you really feel it you will survive and you will make it.

MR: You've got to be willing to pay some dues.

LH: Yes, yes. And that can be — dues as they call it can be very positive, especially, I know when I came up, I didn't have any responsibilities — no wife and kids or anything like that. So I was free to be able to make mistakes and do things and be with my peers. But

when you get to the point where you have a family that's when it can be a problem because that's dues out there.

MR: It's one thing if you're hungry, but something else...

LH: That's right. That's a civic responsibility there.

MR: Well I want to thank you for your time, and I wish you the best of luck with your band and the new CD's coming out, and everything in the future.

LH: Thank you very much, Monk, it was my pleasure.

MR: All right.

LH: Thanks a lot.